THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART VII

Tabreez, February 6, 1846

I don't know whether I mentioned in my last that we were expecting the cholera here. Last year it has been committing dreadful ravages in Afghanistan and in the autumn had come as far as Meshed and Nishahpoor on the way to Tehran. But, thank God, the last news we had of it was that it had turned off to the north among the Turcomanns of the great Khorasan (or Khiva as it is sometimes called) desert. And even had it come to Tehran I see no reason why it should come here, because it might have turned off either north or south from that place or continued its direction from west to east. My friends the Greeks are terribly frightened or rather were. One day I happened to mention that there was a report that the pestilence had arrived at Resht. There were five or six of them in the room and it would have amused you to have seen their blanc faces. It was a false report, but I believe if this disease was to come as near as Tehran not one could be found to remain in the town.

Talking of cholera have you read "the wandering Jew" by Eugene Sue, I have just finished it (the translation in the "Family Herald")[97] and think it a most clever novel, if you have not read it, it will please you much as its aim is to better the condition of the working classes, and unmask the villainy of the Jesuits. It appeared in Nos in this paper from July '44 to October '45. I have seen something of the intrigues of the Lazarist monks in Persia, and these gentry consider themselves as successors to the Jesuits in this country. They have been twice ordered to quit the country with ignominy and disgrace but still hold on altho now their power is much diminished. They formerly had establishments at Ispahan, Ouroumia and here, now they have only a small establishment in the district of Salmas, to the N: W: of this on the frontier. I have had to fight against their plots to injure my friends the American missionaries.[98] And what at first sight seems most strange is that the agent of France, at this court, liberal, revolutionary France, the France of July 1830, supports these black coated gentry with all his power. I believe the reason of this may be that as the French have no interest in these countries and consequently no pretence for placing agents or consuls, and not liking from their vanity, to have nothing to do with the politics of these

[97] A London weekly periodical. The New York Public Library has most of the numbers from 1844–1891 (* DE).

[98] Perkins, op. cit., *passim,* has precisely the same complaints against the Jesuits.

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places they place these priests about the country as spies and political intriguers. I do not recollect whether I told you any thing about these affairs when they occurred as I keep no copies of my letters and forget what I write, if they interest you please tell me and I will let you know something of them. I am glad I have now no more of this sort of work to do; it was a great deal of trouble and I gained nothing by it, besides it sometimes made a little, but very little, bad feeling between me and some of my Greek friends here. These men having all received French education, are as is natural prejudiced in favor of the French cause. It is difficult for a lawyer to plead before a judge when he knows that his Lordship has at the very same time a bribe of twenty five pounds in his pocket to give the verdict against him. This has been my case more than once. One thing which used to amuse me was that I could never make my clients, the missionaries understand that the Govt (Persian) don't care one curse about either them or the Roman Catholics: and often played off one party against the other, here, to endeavour to get bribes from both. They only succeeded with the French who *bled* once or twice pretty freely.

I often think that my connexion with the missionaries is a very odd one. They are partisans and very strict ones, but at the same time liberal, most of them have taken the temperance pledge and the rest scarcely ever touch wine. I, on the contrary like my grog and my song. But with all this they have a great respect for me, and give me about forty tomauns a year for being their agent here. The fact is, I believe they find me useful and therefore take little notice of what they consider my sins and backslidings. They have given me fifteen vol: of tracts which I have never read except "the Pilgrims Progress" and another. They are chiefly about abstract points of puritan doctrine, such as "conversion" "election" "Degrees of grace" etc. and one day I chanced to look through them to find something about "charity" and found nothing; this has given me a disgust for them and I have scarcely looked at them since. Men were no doubt created with different dispositions and qualities like the animals and I do not think I was intended for a puritan.

The Shah, thanks to the care of Dr Bell[99] has recovered from his dangerous attack of the gout. I don't wonder at the newspapers in Europe killing him; he was all but gone. The Prime Minister has been celebrating the Shah's recovery by ruining many of the men about the court, some of them those who had attended upon him most faithfully when speechless and insensible and not expected to live many hours. H: M: is between you and I little better than an ass. He thinks the prime minister a God incarnate and shuts his eyes to the confusion which now reigns in a great part of Persia.

[99] Physician attached to the British mission.

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It is likely that I shall go to Tehran shortly altho this is not certain. Whether I shall be able to get any thing done about my affairs is uncertain. I suspect the Hadji[100] does not like me.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, March 27, 1846*

How does trade go with you? Pray do not fail to let me know when you write. The trade here is a very different one from that at Tabreez. The latter is a great mart for the surrounding countries. This not so much so, altho it is situated in the line of the great route between Arabia and Tartary yet its transit trade is comparatively speaking trifling. The most lucrative trade I know of here, altho certainly not the most respectable, is usury: lending money chiefly on pledges chiefly jewels and shawls at 20, 30, 50, and sometimes to my knowledge 120 pr Cent pr annm! and this, that is, for the lower rates of interest 20 or 30% pr anm for no small sums. The governor of the province of Fars (Persia proper) when last here borrowed about thirty thousand pounds at this rate most of which I believe he has now paid. This money was I believe borrowed without pledges but the usual way is when the amount is only a few thousands or less to take pledges for about double the sum lent. Much money has been made in this during the last twelve years in Tehran, but the commerce is not thought respectable and I fancy (forgive my superstition) that there is a curse attending on it.

The trade of the Greeks at Tabreez is not nearly so good as it has been and for some time back the principals have not been getting much profit; of course the houses at Tabreez which are only agency do not loose [sic] but I suspect the owners of the goods have had some losses lately.

A few days ago I received news of the death of a friend of mine, Capn Todd,[101] poor fellow his head was carried of[f] by a cannon shot at the great battle fought on the banks of the Sutledge last December. He was an officer of the Bengal Horse Artillery and many years in Persia; well read, clever and accomplished, pity such men should be made food for gunpowder. — The last news we had of this victory was only a few days after the battle was fought, there appears to have been much mismanagement, and consequently an unnecessary loss of life but I suppose, that to take Gwalior, as it was a victory, no one will be blamed.

Tehran, March 27, 1846

I wrote you a few hurried lines before leaving Tabreez and now send you this chiefly to inform you of my safe arrival and good health for I have little other news to give you. I presented my book on China to the Shah in person;

100 The Prime Minister.

101 The British Army List for 1845–1847 does not list a Bengal Horse Artillery, probably because it was composed of natives.

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he received it graciously enough but since then I have heard nothing more of it, indeed I have only seen him once since then and only for a few minutes. I do not know whether this book will do me any good but I intend to try. William Cormick has succeeded pretty well, he has been appointed as he wished physician to the late Abbas Meerza's family at Tabreez, but they have not given him his father's pay as he expected. This was a thousand tomauns a year and they have only given William five hundred and one hundred for medicines this I think very fair considering he was just entering the service. We shall most likely be here about twenty days more as it takes some time arranging about how he is to be paid and getting the papers registered etc.

The Shah is now quite well but quite lame of one leg, from an issue which was put into the tendon Achilles by a quack French doctor who made a fortune of about eight or ten thousand pounds in fifteen months and went away with it. The two doctors who attended the Shah in his last illness have also been well paid, they have received from H: M: one thousand tomauns cash two shawls worth about two hundred more and the second class orders of the Lion and Sun each. And this is besides some handsome presents from the Kings mother and some other of his relations. Drs Bell and Cadi,[102] the two doctors above mentioned may have made near a thousand pounds each out of the job.

I have seen the prime minister several times and he has been civil to me which is more than I expected, whether I shall be able to get any thing done in my affairs is very uncertain, my creditors are most unreasonable and will not come to any terms. Col Sheil now the envoy will help me but I am afraid he will be able to do little for me.

I have scarcely been out of the town since I arrived having no horse here, indeed outside there is little to tempt one in the immediate neighbourhood. A dry flat stony plain without herbage and only here and there patches of cultivation. Not like Tabreez where for miles on every side there is a continuation of orchards and vineyards. At Tabreez too we are on much better terms with one another than the Europeans are here. The two Missions English and Russian are at opposite ends of the town and the intercourse of the members composing them is confined to a formal visit every now and then or a dinner nearly as formal. Very different is our little society at Tabreez. Some of the Greek merchants there though odd looking fellows and very queerly dressed, are men of most general information, and besides the dinners at the two consuls and other houses, M' d'Ozeroff keeps open house every Saturday night; and at his parties one meets Persians Russians Greeks and a mixture of all the nations to be found at Tabreez.

[102] Physicians of the British and Russian embassies, respectively.

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Amongst other benefits the Shah has received from our doctor's (Dr Bell) treatment (I say *our* because I do not think the Russian is much of a doctor) is that he has cleared his nose in such a manner that those who were not well accustomed to speak with him could not understand him. I was most agreeably surprised on entering the room to find that I could understand all he said and talked away in a manner that appeared to surprise some of the courtiers who expect a man to be rather abashed when first presented.

I dine with Coll Sheil two or three times a week and have dined once with Prince Dolgorouki,[103] the Russian Envoy, and once with Count de Sartiges the French agent. The latter's dinners are by far the most agreeable. He is a man of about forty and has been travelling attached to different missions all his life. He gave me some curious facts about the slaves in north and south America, where he has travelled much.

Tehran, May 7, 1846

I wrote to you last month from this place and then hoped to have addressed my next from Tabreez. You will see by the date that I am still here, and as yet I have been able to get nothing done, however I have yet hopes, but this life of loitering about the court and attending the Prime ministers levies is to me a most miserable one. It is very true that in all countries a man who has business with great people must expect to kick his heels about lobbies and ante-rooms, but then in Europe there is this great difference that the man you are dancing attendance upon, generally speaking, is not one who excites nothing but contempt, I can not tell you the misery I sometimes feel whilst I am waiting for an opportunity to speak to the Hadji (Prime Minister) on my affairs, altho I see Princes of the blood no better off than I am; and therefore I sometimes think that this feeling of annoyance is one that I ought to get over. One reason why I have never been able to come to any arrangement with my creditors is that they are affraid to come to any settlement with me until the Govt have made some arrangement with Charles because they consider the government as first creditor. This is one amongst the difficulties with which I have to contend, but it would be neither entertaining nor useful to any one to trouble you with any more of these details, at present. If I can do any thing satisfactory you may be sure I shall not fail to let you know.

We have very little news in this dull place. The Shah whose death you saw announced last autumn is now pretty free from gout and in very good health, the French doctor who formerly treated him and left Persia with a fortune has

[103] Dmitri Ivanovich Dolgorouki, 1816–1867, member of the famous family of that name. A "career" diplomat, he had held posts in almost all the capitals of Europe and the Near East.

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lamed him of one leg, by putting an issue into it. Our doctor Dr Bell and the Russian Dr Cadi have now made over their patient to a French doctor of the name of Cloqué newly arrived, who is to have three thousand tomauns a year pay besides his own private practice so he is in a fair way of making his fortune. Our doctor and the Russian are both rather annoyed and with reason. They brought the king round when he was at death's door and now they are superceded. It is true they are both physicians to missions and were called in because there was no other doctor here, but still they do not like being sent off in this way, altho they have been very well paid having made about a thousand pounds each.

Talking of doctors reminds me that there has been a most curious disease at Kashan or rather at a village near, which I do not know whether I mentioned in my last letter. The people are siezed with a violent head ache and go mad after a few hours.[104] Like all extraordinary things in Persia, the Persians must add the marvellous to it. And they say that one of its wonders is that, when the people have it, if they strike any one the person struck goes mad too. Some people were mentioning this in a room where I was and saying how extraordinary it was, "not at all" said a queer old fellow "our prime minister has had it many years, and has been beating all Persia!"

It was very stupid of me to write you of the kings dangerous illness, and then not tell you of his recovery. I keep no copies of my letters nor even a memorandum of what I write but must do the latter in the future. In cases of this kind, would not the people at the Foreign Office answer a question, as to whether the Shah was dead or not; I should think they would, if they were tried, for I am told they are civil. In fact it is civil of them forwarding our letters, which certainly forms no part of their duty.

You are right in supposing that it is my friend Layard[105] who is making the discoveries near Nineveh. I have not yet heard the particulars but they say they are most interesting. I hope it may be some thing substantial for him. He wants it poor fellow.

I walk about a good deal here, for a very good reason, I have no horse. The nightingales are in full song, the roses just beginning. I believe you have no yellow roses in England here they are in plenty both single and double, the double is a very fine tree growing sometimes eight feet high or even higher. The smell is not good. I am pretty sure we have some roses here which are not known in England and many different varieties of fruit. M' d'Ozeroff who I have mentioned to you, the Russian Consul Genl at Tabreez, has arrived here

104 Probably sunstroke. The town is known for its excessive heat during the summer.

105 Sir Henry Layard, the famous discoverer of the ruins at the site of Nineveh. Layard mentions Edward by name in his *Early adventures in Persia*, v. 1, p. 308 ff.

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to resume his former post, Secretary of legation. The man for whom he was acting having returned we are all very sorry to loose him at Tabreez the other is not half such a good fellow. I am affraid I shall not be able to leave Tehran with Dr Cormick and when he goes I shall indeed have to "rough it." We came down here post and therefore have no furniture dishes etc and there are no such things as furnished lodgings in Persia. He has a pretty good Persian bed which he sent from Tabreez before him. I have nothing but a quilt in which I roll myself on the floor with my fur pelisse and other clothes under my head for a pillow. How odd people would think it if a man going from London to stay a month at Liverpool, must either send his bed before him, take it with him, or buy one there. It is things of this kind which make Persia in many respects by no means a cheap country. We do not get so many comforts for the same amount spent, as could be had in England. The lodging we are in is a vile one for bad smells there is a mixture of the smell of a distillery of arrack a bad drain and other abominations.

[We have only the conclusion of this letter, important for the fortunes of Edward in Persia. He has apparently been able to assure the Hadji of Charles' forthcoming return to Persia.]

. . . health and strength, for this, and I hope I shall not flinch from it. And altho I do not dispair of Charles regaining his position in Persia he will have a cruel ordeal to go through at first. He will feel how much his position has changed. But I believe the Hadji is sincere in stating that he will re-establish him in his position and he is certainly able to do so if he wishes even if Charles owed twice as much as he does.

Altho I have often been received angrily by the Prime Minsr (he often receives me with a sort of howl something like a jackall) I must at the same time acknowledge that I have experienced kindness from other Persians where I little expected it. Particularly from a certain Mahomed Allee Bey, intendant of the Shahs household. Indeed I have made some acquaintances here which may be useful to Charles if he returns. And those who served with him or under him being now almost all high up in the service, many of them governors of provinces and married to Princesses, will be of service to him.

P: S: Tehran, June 30, [1846]. I had a curious instance of the excessive dryness of this climate a few days ago. Touching the pillars which support a sort of gallery in the house where M. Cloqué the kings doctor lives, I found they gave out strong electric sparks. I mentioned this to the Count de Sartige who has lived in this house some time and he said he had frequently observed it. What effect living in this rarified state has upon us I know not but for my part I like a little damp and am always delighted with rains of spring and autumn.

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[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, January 5, 1847*

I trust this will find you in England and that you will finally find it to your advantage to settle there, perhaps I have adopted some of the Persian fear of water travelling, but I can not but think of the risks you run in going backwards and forward from England to America, particularly when I see accounts in the newspapers of the accidents which happen to the Great Britain[106] and the other large steamers. We have as yet no news as to whether they have succeeded in getting this unfortunate ship off or not, as the last news we have from Europe is the 10*th* November from Paris. We expect the monthly post in two or three days when we shall most likely have news up to the 10*th* Decr from Paris.

The Prince still keeps me translating from the natural history, which he is exceedingly I was going to say childishly fond of. The work I want to be about is a translation of a Gazeteer, which I could do now having found a Turkish Geography from which I could get the spelling of the names of the places in the Arabic letters, which would do for the Persian. I do not like these animals at all, translating natural history does me no good, and perhaps not much more to the Prince. But he who pays the piper has a right to choose the tune. He is remarkably fond of pictures and paints a little himself. He has a large collection of pictures chiefly copper plates, some of them pretty good ones, amongst these he has a large book full of the figures of animals; he looks this over and over and then tells me to write the history of any which take his fancy. Now the Gazeteer would be a respectable work, and besides if I finished it, and presented a copy to the King, it might do me good in many ways. You will perhaps be surprised to hear that we have now in Tabreez no less than sixteen printing establishments, and more in Tehran, in fact books have become so cheap in Persia that it has done much injury to the trade of the copyists; still very fine manuscripts hold their price and there are several copies of the Shah-Nāmeh (the Persian Homer) which could not be bought for less than a hundred pounds and you might perhaps buy a printed one for as many sixpences.[107]

You will be glad to hear that the cholera has ceased here and that I and my friends (except poor Glen at Tehran) have been spared. It is supposed to have carried off from 15 to 20,000 of the inhabitants of this province, and perhaps nearly as many from some of the other provinces of Persia. I sincerely trust

[106] The *Great Britain*, launched in 1843, was the largest iron steamboat of her time. She was operated successfully on the trans-Atlantic run until she went aground on the Irish coast, September, 1846. Although exposed to the elements for eleven months, she was refloated and continued in service for some time afterwards. Cf. E. K. Cheverton, *Steamships and their story*, London, 1911, p. 123 ff.

[107] The New York Public Library has a very fine illuminated and illustrated ms. copy of the Shāhnāmeh in the Spencer Collection; for its description by the late Prof. Gottheil, cf. its *Bulletin*, v. 30, p. 343-354.

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it may not visit Europe, but as it appears to be marching towards Russia I have my fears.

We have had two English travellers here this year which is unusual. Mr Seymour[108] in the summer and now Mr Tasker, the former has gone back to England after visiting Georgia Persia Arabia Turkey etc. The latter has all his troubles before him, as he is just going to start to visit the antiquities of Kermanshan, perhaps the coldest part of Persia. He stands a chance in this hard weather of being blocked up in some village, and having to live in a cow house for some time if nothing worse happens to him. It is agreeable to see English faces and for some years back I have seen but few of them. Since the detachment of officers and serjeants left Persia in '39 we have seen very few Englishmen.

Tabreez, January 6, 1847

To day is the Greek and Russian X'mas day, but unfortunately the present Russian Consul General is a miserable fellow who shuts himself up in his house and will see no one, very unlike that good hearted jovial fellow M' d'Ozeroff who is now on leave in Russia, indeed he was only acting here during this ones absence his place being secretary of legation at Tehran. He however would like to get appointed here as the pay is better and it is an independent place.

Col Sheil goes home on leave in the spring and then Col Farrant[109] will be left in charge, the latter came out newly married last autumn. He had a most miserable journey, he was laid up dangerously ill at Constantinople, both he and his wife were ill at Erzeroom, and arriving here when cholera was ravaging the country, his favorite servant was carried off by that disease on the march.

I am much disappointed at having had no letters from you this month but hope to receive one by the courier who arrives in a day or two.

Tabreez, January 9, 1847

As our post from Tehran has been delayed some days and that from Europe has arrived a little before its usual time I have the pleasure of answering yours of the 5th Novr which arrived the day before yesterday. I have been much amused by the route it appears to have taken, for instead of coming direct by the Trebizonde steamers it has been travelling about Germany. You have directed it "Edwd Burgess Esquire Tabreez, to the care of James Brant Esquire Erzeroom." But underneath the word "Erzeroom" and close to it there is "Prussia." But I am not sure whether this is in your handwriting or not. It has however the Hamburg

108 Henry Danby Seymour, translator and editor of Ferrier's *Caravan journeys and wanderings in Persia.* No record can be found of the following traveler, Mr. Tasker.

109 Cf. note. 86.

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post mark on it. And some kind fellow has written on it in a lawyer-like hand "Erzerum, Armenia" and so it has found its way here. You ought to have written on it "pr Pininsular and Oriental steamers" and then it would have come all right. My friends the Greeks tell me that these steamers start from Southampton and I observe my dear Fathers letter has written on it "Via Southampton." There is also another company now sending their boats from England to Const[le] and Trebizonde but these start from Liverpool. As the P: and O: Co boats now come direct and arrive at Constantinople in about fifteen days, a letter will not take more than a month to come here and the same to go home.

I see a long story in the newspapers about disturbances in Persia, the greater part of which are untrue, and also a most horrible account of the ravaging of the Nestorian country by Beder Khan Bey which has more truth in it.[110] I trust you have not been alarmed by the accounts of the cholera here, and that my letters have reached you regularly.

There has been a row in Tehran about a Frenchman, a friend of mine, having flogged his servant for theft to such a degree that he died. The people demanded the blood of the Frenchman in exchange for that of the man who was flogged to death, who was a Mahomedan. The thing is not settled yet and I suppose the Frenchman will have to pay. Altho' he is a queer fish, I can not think that he would have the barbarity to flog a man to death and he denies that the man was flogged by his orders, he says that his other servants did it to make the man confess. But he formerly belonged to the army serving in Algeria where they see and do very queer things. — The affair is not yet settled. —

Troops are marching for Khorasan where there have been some disturbances but nothing like so serious as stated in the papers. — I pity the poor soldiers having to march in such weather; ill clothed and fed — and I am thankful that I am not likely to have a journey this winter.

Tabreez, February 2, 1847

I have just received a note from Tehran which has pleased me, it informs me that some translations which I sent for the Hadji have been presented, and that he liked them much. I intend to send him some more by the next post and still don't dispair of getting my place here confirmed by the Shah, with an increase of pay of course, but this as I before explained all depends upon the Hadji.

Our new Consul, Mr Richard Stevens, has not yet arrived. When he comes Abbott will have to go to Tehran, and a most cold journey he will have until he gets more than half way, the winter in this upper country is most severe, the

[110] For a detailed account see Thomas Laurie, *Dr. Grant and the mountain Nestorians*, Boston, 1856, p. 323–365.

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thermometer early in the morning seldom standing much above zero of Faren[t]. A poor fellow arrived the other day with the fingers of one hand frozen, they were a mass of matter and I suppose the first joints will drop off. We have not much snow here, indeed the snow is never very deep about Tabreez except in the drifts and on the hills, perhaps a great part of the plain being salt and the rest stoney may account in some measure for the snows not remaining. I hear that the snow is very deep about our villages and the wolves are committing great ravages, they have carried off half the dogs belonging to Kara Chibuk, they prowl about the village and if they can find a dog alone they sieze him carry him off tear him in pieces and eat him. A man took a cow out to water and was attacked by four wolves he ran one way and the cow the other both however got off scathless, except that the cow lost the end of her tail which the brutes tore off. Perhaps the most extraordinary thing about these animals is their strength of jaw. Some years ago I had a greyhound who had his side ripped open by a single bite, and I recollect seeing a tame wolf here who used to crunch mutton bones as we do radishes. Several men have been eaten by them in the Maranghd district, but none thank God from our villages. I have known much colder weather here, for in the winter of '45 the thermometer went as low as twenty degrees below zero, but I never recollect the hard weather being of such continuance and without a change. The snow fell in the middle of November and we have had slight falls dull cloudy weather and wind and drifts with little intermission ever since. In the mean time I continue to wage war upon the ducks with pretty good success; the other day I was out shooting and I shot two right and left — one fell into the pond on which they had been swimming and my pointer Juno who retrieves pretty well, did not like to go into the water to bring it out but went barking round the side. I however was not going to lose my duck, and so I made madam Juno do her duty and pushed her into the water. She brought out the duck but as soon as she had come out every hair was like a seperate icicle, and she looked something like a dog of frosted silver. She is too thin skinned and delecate for this winter work and sometimes I have had to put her on a horse to carry her home when she has been much in the water. The water of these ponds, coming from under ground immediately into the pond never freezes in the hardest weather, and they are consequently the resort of the ducks at this season.

The Prince has at length determined to have the Turkish work on Geography translated and we have already set about it, many things will of course have to be altered, as the book was written above a hundred years ago, but it is a good work, and by correcting it with the most modern Gazeteers I can find, I hope to make a creditable thing of it. His fondness for natural history is most amusing. I believe I told you that I have already translated for him, the history

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of some animals out of Bewick and other books. He does not want any more just now and I hope he won't want any more of them but give me other work to do, for I am not fond of these animals, it appears to me such childish sort of work.

We have had an English traveller here lately, and as since the Egyptian rout was opened between England and India, they are very rare, we are much pleased to see them. His name Mr Joseph Tasker. I know nothing about his family except that they are Catholic, and have a place in Essex. He has been travelling some years in Turkey and Arabia. I am sorry he comes to Persia in such a bad season for of all countries to visit in the winter, Persia is the worst, and he has gone into one of the coldest districts viz Koordistan, so he won't learn much of the country. Like most travellers he is travelling more to look after the antiquities than any thing else. I believe he intends to travel over a great part of Persia, and so I hope he may be in the country in spring summer and autumn also, as I should be sorry any one should return to Europe, with such an idea of this country as he would get from a winter tour in it.

I keep my health well in all this cold, and as we hear nothing of the cholera in this province we hope that we have done with it, and that it may not appear again next year. It seems to have gone to the Northward as it has declared itself in the Russian Trans-Caucasian provinces. God grant it may not reach Europe and approach you.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, July 6, 1847*

Has the immense trade there has been in grain lately to Europe, brought nothing to you? I hoped as you were connected with America you might have got some good commissions.

Mr Stevens now our consul here, has gained nothing by his appointment. He was vice consul at Samsoon on the Black Sea with 300 a year pay and liberty to trade; he was agent for the British steamers and that and his trade, cleared him after paying all expenses upwards of two thousand pounds the last year he was there. His trade was chiefly buying grain and Valonia (acorn cups used in dyeing) for the merchants at Constantinople. But being in partnership with Brants house which had branches at Erzeroom and Kaiseria, which are losing concerns, his profits went to make up the losses. Here he has £600 a year and no trade. And as the expenses of this consulate are much heavier than that of Samsoon I do not think he saves anything. But I believe he could not refuse the appointment without quitting the service. The place here is much higher in point of station and consideration, our consuls here being like little ambassadors.

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Meerza Saduck who some years ago went to England to study medicine has just returned. He came from England to Constantinople by way of the Rhine and the Danube which two rivers have now a canal connecting them, so that a man can pass through the heart of Europe by river navigation.[111] He states that the Russian government have a similar contemplation between the Don and Volga.[112] This will connect the Caspian with the Black Sea and if it is opened we shall I hope be able to send Persian grain from this province to England by water carriage; it would be shipped at Astard (or some port near it) the nearest port to Ardebil. And as this is near one of the most extensive and productive grain districts in the north of Persia, the wheat could often be delivered at the water side at about S 10/ or S 12/ the Q^r and from thence you would have water carriage to London. Grain would not be the only Persian produce then exported which is now useless on account of the heavy land carriage. Had the countries about the Don and Volga been in the hands of any other European power except Russia this canal would have been opened long ago. But I have no hope from that stupid, barbarous, and tyrannical government, who with unbounded resources at their command appear to do less for agriculture and commerce than even the Asiatics. Who else with the power they have had now more than a hundred years, would not have opened a water communication into central Asia when the whole expense was that of cutting a canal not more than a hundred miles long.

The Greeks have driven almost every one else out of the trade here, they have beaten even the Persians who had a considerable trade in British manufactures from Constantinople. Mr Ede does a little in what you would in America call *notions* (I believe) viz little lots of guns pistols, some times tea and sugar and other things but not much in the staple trade of the country, Cotton manufactures, which are sold in bulk and chiefly for the interior.

A month ago the Prince talked of going to a place called Sir-Aub where there is a most abundant spring of pure hot-water over which a bath has been constructed. It is in a cool upland district about a hundred miles off in the direction of the Caspian, and is a part of the corn country mentioned above. The arrival

111 The "Ludwigs-Donau-Main Kanal" opened for navigation July 15th, 1846, cf. H. Brüschwein, *Der Gedanke einer Rhein-Main-Donau Verbindung in seiner geschichtlicher Entwicklung*, Regensberg, 1928, p. 59. Cf. also Gaston Raphael, "La grande voie fluviale Rhin-Danube" in *L'action nationale*, t. 18 (1922), p. 165 ff., where its subsequent history is described.

112 This canal has never been built. Discussed from the days of Peter the Great, its proposed construction reached its highest point in 1929, cf. A. S. Aksamityi, *The Volga-Don deep waterway*, Moscow, 1929, where the beginning of the project is actually announced, as well as plans for its completion by 1935–36. It is interesting to note that a 1939 speech by Molotoff to the 18th Conference of the All-Union Communist Party includes the official reasons for the failure to complete the canal project.

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of the Princes mother and uncle on their way to Mecca has prevented his journey which I am sorry for because if he had gone he would have taken me with him and I might from thence have gone on to the Caspian, only I believe about three or four stages, and I should have seen two things which after such a long absence would have given me much pleasure. A wooded country and (to the sight) a boundless sea.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Tabreez, August 5, 1847*

A few days ago I received Joe Turpin's letter of the *2nd* July written at my Mother's request as she was too unwell to write herself. He tells me that you grieve much about my position. My dear Father this is wrong. My position except from the fact of being in debt, and in pledge for these debts, is by no means a bad one. My creditors now seldom annoy me. I am under no restraint and altho my pay is small, my position with the Prince causes me to be treated with much greater respect and consideration than I was when I was a merchant. I am very seldom hard worked; and I like my work. I am never so happy as when I have finished a hard days work at my translations. My spirits are then as high as a schoolboy just burst out of school. And I am convinced that amongst the happiest people in this world are those who are the hardest worked. The knowledge I am gaining of the people, their customs and habits, produce, revenue and other matters appertaining to the govt of the country, can not fail at some time or other, to turn out to my advantage. Perhaps no Englishman has been placed in such a situation as I am for gaining an intimate acquaintance with the people. I heard it said that in England the most agreeable men in society, and those who from their general knowledge are most likely to get on in politics, are the lawyers. I am here both lawyer and magistrate; before the Prince and my superiors I often act as lawyer, there I have to plead. But with regard to the inhabitants of the villages I have the charge of, I have to judge; sometimes to punish, sometimes to put in force the decisions of the civil courts; I have to make myself acquainted with all sorts of disputes now about the possession of a vineyard or corn lands and then about a broken head or a drove of stolen cattle.

I have yet received no answer from Col Sheil about your application for leave for me to go to England, but I am expecting one by the courier who ought to arrive to day as I wrote to him myself he will I have no doubt answer my letter. Even if the Hadji gives me leave there must be an order to my creditors not to molest me or prevent my going. By the last post a letter arrived in twenty-six days from Manchester. And if it was not for the quarantine at Trebizonde I could get home well in a month. The quarantine is ten days and there are no means of avoiding it. From thence there are steamers once a week to England.

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This is the quickest route but perhaps not the cheapest. The passage money is high. I think I could go to England and back in six months well, and have upwards of three months perhaps four in England. It would not do to be more than six months away if I wanted to keep my place here. I should then, (in case I stayed away more than six months) perhaps loose the villages and much injure my prospects.

August 7th. The courier is in from Tehran and goes on towards Erzeroom, to day in answer to my letter to Col Sheil, for leave to go home, I give you the following extract from his letter which is all he writes on the subject. "Hadji Meerza Agasi has given a positive refusal to your departure from Persia before the arrival of your brother." This being the case I have no other alternative except one which I am sure neither you nor my dear Mother would wish me to take advantage of. That of running away. Because this would be dishonourable. And in every situation in which I have been placed, I have never forgot that I am your son and I have endeavoured never to do any thing which might bring disgrace on my dear Father and my dear Mother. Nothing would be easier than for me to quit the country without leave. I am often absent from Tabreez ten or fifteen days at a time, and thirty-six hours would carry me over the frontier. My never having been put in prison, I owe certainly to the fact of people having placed confidence in me. And if the feeling of never doing anything to bring disgrace on our family, did not prevent my acting wrong, ought not the confidence thus placed in me to have the same effect. When in 1840 I was at Ispahan, had either the Shah or his prime minister treated me with indignity, the whole court and camp, and all the foreign missions there, would have exclaimed against this proceeding, and most likely have prevented it. There was then neither Envoy or Consul in the country to protect me — All political relations between the countries were broken off. I owed my protection to my character and to that only. How careful then ought I be to keep that character unsullied. Adieu my dear father, God bless you and preserve you."[113]

[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Kara Chibuk, in the district of Maranghd, October 18, 1847*

I a few days ago received a letter from my cousin Foljambe informing me of my poor Mothers death.[114] O my dear Father, by my own grief, I can in some measure imagine what your affliction must have been. I never felt my absence

[113] Edward now seems to have resigned himself to the prospect of remaining in Persia for the rest of his life.

[114] August, 1847.

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from England so cruel as at this moment, when I might have been near to comfort and soothe you. Gods will be done, it is no doubt wrong perhaps even wicked to grieve and repine, but surely the loss of such a mother as mine may excuse a son's tears. I have no letter from you and therefore I do not know whether George was in England at the time or not. I trust he was. T. Foljambe's letter is most kind, he says you had written to me. I suppose the letter has been detained some where or miscarried.

My griefs do not prevent my attending to the business which brought me here, and my arrival was just in time to prevent some disturbances and perhaps bloodshed in the town of Binaub which the villages adjoin. In the villages under my charge all, thank God, was quiet. The people had heard of the Princes abrupt departure from Tabreez, (mentioned in my letter to you on the 5*th* or 6*th* of this month) with many exagerations, such as that he had been sent for as a state criminal, had run the country, etc. and they were about despatching a messenger to see what had become of me.

I believe all will go well with the Prince and it is very probable that he may be reinstated in his govt.[115] The accounts he had heard of the slanders against him were much exagerated and I believe our government will support him. Few Persian Princes have been so truly the poor man's friend as Bahman Meerza, and amongst the lower and middle classes his departure is universally deplored. The country, generally, is much more quiet than I had expected. The town of Tabreez on the contrary is in confusion. A few days ago the head of police was attacked, murdered, and many of his people wounded in broad-day, by a band of ruffians who after the deed marched through the town, the provisional governor not having courage enough to seize them.

[Edward Burgess to George Burgess] *Tabreez, April 4, 1848*

I know you will be anxious to know how the world is going with me, in these troublous times, at least they are so for my master Bahman Meerza, and for a great many people in Persia. I still remain in my former position attached to the young Prince's Bahman Meerza's sons, and altho like all who stand by a fallen house, I am sufficiently ill off, I should not like to leave them, I have much affection both for them and their father, and altho I have as yet got no pay since last September, I think it would be wrong to leave them. I am no worse off than the greater part of his followers, and I believe I shall get my pay in a day or two, at least the greater part of the arrears, and I have also some hopes that if I remain in my present position, arrangements will be made to enable me to get my salary regularly. Nothing of importance has taken place since Bahman

[115] He was exiled to Russia by his brother, Mohammed Shah.

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Meerza went to the Russian Mission and I should think little will be done until the answer to the dispatches of the Russian minister arrive from St Petersburgh, and until the arrival of the Shah's mother who is away on a pilgrimage to Mecca. We expect both these arrivals within the next fifteen or twenty days. Bahman Meerza and the Shah are from the same mother, and it is supposed the younger son is the favourite. In fact the Shah has no affection for any one except the Prime minister even his own mother he has treated with unkindness. But she is a woman of great talent and energy and we, Bahman Meerza's followers, are anxiously wishing for her arrival, as we think her influence, if the king is not utterly dead to all sense of shame, may cause a change of measures. I have not yet been deprived of the offices I held under Bahman Meerza, the management of the villages and the kings stud but I fully expect to be so, as the heir apparent will most likely give these places to some of his own people. I shall not give them up until obliged to do so, as I am not sure yet but that I may have to remain in this province, and if so the more I have in my hands the better.

The Heir apparent[116] appears at present quite unfit for business, all the power and patronage is in the hands of a few of his own people: in fact since his arrival he has done little but give away places to those about him and amuse himself. Several men of the first rank and standing in the country for talent were appointed to come here as ministers; but not one has yet quitted Tehran, indeed they refuse to do so, until almost all the people who now surround the young Prince are removed, and ordered to return to Tehran. These last are making hay while the sun shines, and the Vale-Ahd (Heir apparent) seemed determined not to give them up. There will be some tremendous disputes between him and the prime minister in fact these have already begun, it will be curious to see how they will end; in fact things can not go on as at present, for in a short time there will not be a thousand pounds of available revenue in the province; all will be swallowed up by the young Prince's courtiers. Now when you consider that the Shah's great power consists in the troops drawn from this province,[117] which troops can not do altogether without pay and clothing, and with the rebellion raging in Khorassan, in a short time you may fancy what a mess they will be in.

This French revolution[118] (I mean that of last February for they may have had twenty others since that time) has of course destroyed the French influence in this country. In fact with M. Giuzot[119] one half of the diplomatic servants of the

116 Nasir-i-Din, then fifteen years of age.

117 The backbone of the army was composed of the levies from the province of Azerbaijan, of which Tabriz is the capital.

118 The abdication of Louis-Philippe in favor of his grandson precipitated the 1848 revolution which brought the Second Empire to an end, and inaugurated the brief Second Republic.

119 Guizot was Louis-Philippe's chief minister.

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French govt will go down with a run. Count de Sartiges the French Chargé d'affaires at Tehran, was one of his people, and so we suppose he is done for. I for one do not pity him, for it was he who upset Bahman Meerza.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Tabreez, May 6, 1848*

The Prince Bahman Meerza's affairs have taken a curious turn, it is now arranged that he retires to Russia and as he can not take me with him, I must look out for a place with the Heir apparent. The former is expected here in a few days, and he has already written me a very kind letter giving me permission to look out for myself and thanking me for my services. But he has not yet paid me altho' I believe he will do so. The son here has begged me to remain with the family until they are fairly off so I have not yet quitted their service. I do not think I shall have much difficulty in getting placed with the young Prince our present governor unless he should be vexed at my having made myself so prominent in the service of his uncle. — This I do not expect.

The affairs in France have as you may suppose made a great impression in this country, and my translations of the newspapers are looked for with much eagerness. Thank God we are all quiet in England. And I hope we shall remain so.

I am, as usual at this season, very busy gardening. Locusts have again appeared in the district of Khoee, and many people are affraid they will do much mischief this year. They are yet small and have not begun their depradations; how easy it would be for an energetic govt to destroy the eggs, by offering a premium for them like one of our Saxon kings with the wolfs heads.

The king's mother has returned from the pilgrimage and is taking part with her son Bahman Meerza against the Hadji, it is not improbable that she may quit Persia with Bahman Meerza, she is terribly cut up at the Shah's treatment of him.

Affairs in Khorassan[120] look bad and the rebels have had some success against the Shah's troops, it is very probable that that country may not be settled for some time to come.

My friends the American missionaries are much pleased with the news from Europe. They hope that all the world are going to be republic.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Tabreez, September 17, 1848*

Strange events have occurred since I last wrote to you. Mahomed Shah is no more, and his son the young Heir apparent whose service I had just entered Naser i Deen Shah (long may he reign) is king instead.[121] He was proclaimed

[120] This marks the beginning of the rebellion of Salar, a Kajar noble, who succeeded in maintaining himself for some two years after the death of the Persian shah.

[121] Cf. Sykes, *History of Persia*, v. 2, p. 339.

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here some days ago and starts for Tehran with a force of I suppose about ten thousand men of all arms tomorrow. He has already bestowed upon me the appointment of chief Interpreter and has given me his royal autograph, granting me this appointment; my firman (commission) granting me this post is not yet sealed because the large seal is not yet cut or engraved, my pay is not fixed and will not be, until I arrive at Tehran, that of the late chief Interpreter, who died of cholera in '46 was very high, about one thousand ducats a year say £450 – –. The king treats me with great kindness and I have no doubt I shall get on well. We do not expect much opposition on the road, perhaps, which God grant, none at all. But we go prepared to meet it. Even I and my servant are fully armed. I can not describe the enthusiasm of all the govt servants, I know more than one man who has sold almost every thing he had, to enable him to march with the Shah to Tehran, trusting to his good luck to come in for a share of the good things at the capital. I am much in the same position, and as I have received no pay should have been hard run if it had not been for my friend Mr Stevens our Consul, who will advance me something against the govt bonds, drawn on the revenues of the custom-house for my pay. (the old pay of two hundred ducats a year).

You are I dare say surprised that the people should come forward to serve this young king seeing that his govt during the last six months as I have often informed you has been as bad as need be, and he was by no means popular. But the people consider him as *their* king and both nobles and people are determined to put him on the throne. And they would consider it the highest disgrace if they allowed any other province to interrupt the succession by putting another on the throne. From want of money I have had the greatest difficulty in making up my camp equipment, humble as it is, but when you consider that we shall in all probability, not be in a house or perhaps not within walls until we get to Tehran, you may suppose that a man can not travel very lightly. I am in high spirits at our departure and shall give you all the news as we go along the road, as opportunities occur for sending letters.

I am very glad that you made no further application to the Foreign Office about me, the govt always look shy upon a man who bothers them, and if I had not been in debt, there is no reason (don't laugh) why I should not have been an ambassador by this time, or something like it. I have been refused employment in the British service more than once because of the position Charles has placed me in. In your letter you write "Tell me whether you are in debt on your own seperate individual account and to what amount etc." My letter of the spring of 1846 which went along with the Hadji's letter to Charles will explain this. The amount for which I am liable is about Ts 25,000 say £12,500, these debts

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were incurred some by going bond in exchange for Charles when the latter was over due, some money borrowed and paid to Charles' creditors, for galls, shawls and other goods bought and sent to Constantinople and the proceeds paid against Charles' debts here, and all my debts as I can prove most fully were incurred directly or indirectly by the position in which Charles has placed me by taking out of Persia some £35,000 worth of property and not accounting for a sixpence. No "process of law" resembling "bankruptcy" has been instituted either against me or Charles either jointly or seperately. I have never been in prison, except when at Tehran the Hadji (Prime minister) refused to allow me to leave the town until Charles came. This was something like being a prisoner on parole. I have been at times much annoyed by my creditors dunning me, and owe it to the kind protection of the British and Persian Governments that nothing worse has happened to me. In Persia they flog debtors, and when they find they can get nothing out of them by such means they often get a quittance. In fact I think that the Persians are, taking the difference of manners into consideration, much more lenient than we were at least twenty years ago. Such horrible barbarity as keeping a man in prison all his life because he owed money and could not pay perhaps from no fault of his was never heard of in Persia. In fact there are few countries where a man has such a chance of getting out of difficulties as Persia. And I think that with a very little assistance from Charles I could pay all these debts.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, March 31, 1849*

Thank God I have at last one of your letters to answer, I received yours of the 11*th* Dec the day before yesterday. You do not say anything about the property my Mother left and whether the letter certified by the British Consul at Tabreez was satisfactory or not. I mean that I wrote to uncle George Ridsdale appointing you my agent to act in this matter; What is the probable amount of the property? I know nothing about canal shares, what I grumble about so much in you and my father is that you will not answer even questions on business that I may put to you.

I am right glad you have not sold the shawl, it is worth twenty or perhaps much more here, if I recollect right I was offered sixty tomauns for it at Tabreez, this would be about £27 – – But it appears your friends the Americans don't know the value of such things. I am very glad Valeria has it and that it has not passed out of the family. These things are given to us as marks of approval of our conduct, and are worn once as scarfs, in the presence of the giver, whether King or Prince, and afterwards we do what we like with them, unfortunately I have been so ill off of late years that I have been obliged to sell mine. I sold two

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in Tabreez a few months ago, they had been given me by Bahman Meerza and his son, and I should have liked to have kept them, but I was short of money and I got sixty tomauns for them, a very good price; I got another shawl at the no-roze (21*st* March Persian new year) but not a very good one, it is only worth about twenty tomauns. I have not yet sold it and hope not to do so.

My present pay Ts 400 -- (four hundred tomauns) a year is good pay for the country, but it is not paid regularly and I have now long arrears of pay to claim. In fact the government now have no money and they are not likely to have much for some time to come, last years revenues were swallowed up by the late Prime minister and his people, and as in Persia the first instalment of the taxes, are not due until April or May, we can not expect much to come in from the provinces yet; I am in favor with the King and the Prime minister[122] and I do not dispair of getting on well, but at present it is rather up hill work.

We have had some disturbances from the mutiny of three regiments of soldiers now happily finished.

Our minister Col Shiel, has not yet arrived from England, but he is expected in about a month. When he arrives our present Chargé d'affaires, Col Farrant will most likely go home, we shall be sorry to lose him, he is a remarkably good-hearted, hospitable man.

At present I am fixed here, but it is not unlikely that I may get some appointment in the provinces, which I shall try for if I find that I do not make much here. The Shah talks of moving in the summer but I think it probable that want of money may prevent his leaving the neighbourhood of Tehran.

You never told me whether the paterns of Persian silk and cotton goods were worth any thing, and whether they were admired or not. I should like to hear about this.

I was sorry to learn from the newspapers that the cholera had extended its ravages to America. It has I learn, been very slight in London, only about a hundred cases in a week out of a population of two millions, in '35 we lost (deaths) for two days five hundred a day at Tabreez out of a population of certainly not then more than a hundred thousand. In the cholera of '46, seven or eight thousand died in Tabreez and in '47 about half the number. Persia is now thank God free from it.

The former Prime minister now an exile at Kerbelai, has got into some theological disputes with the Mollahs of that place, and has been pelted by the people. His enormous wealth has been confiscated by the crown at least all that was not plundered by the people in the disturbances which succeeded the late king's death.

(To be concluded)

122 Mirza Taki Khan, Amir-i-Nizam, premier 1848–1851.

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